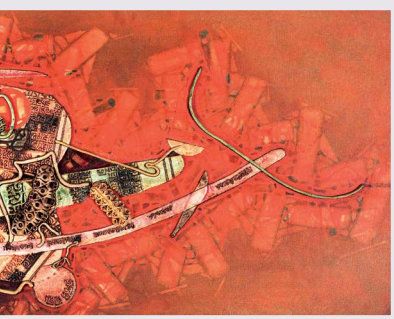
INTERESTINGLY, WHEREAS **MOST ARTISTS TRANSITIONING TOWARDS ABSTRACTION** DREW FROM VISUAL CUES, DAVE WAS INSPIRED BY SOUND



words sound. In her introductory essay in *Neither Earth Nor Sky*, Thacker elaborates: "Sound—both in its static form, *anahata dhwani*, and in its vibratory form, *naad dhwani*—forms a praxis on which the aesthetic of culture is generated and woven.... Thus, experiencing and expressing abstraction as sound, rhythm and equilibrium is the genesis of Asian civilisational routes." And while these religious icons keep popping up from time to time in Dave's works, they are often stripped of their religious significance and used purely as visual symbols, as part of our shared visual vocabulary in the Indian subcontinent.

These sonic influences can be seen in Dave's oil-and-encaustic canvases (largely untitled) from the '70s and '80s in particular—works that feel like they have been freshly dug up at an archaeological dig, or unearthed from an alien spacecraft in a sci-fi movie. The 'scripts' formed by Dave's 'aksharas', the made-up letters and words that are crucial elements or motifs in a lot of his work from this era, are exercises in collective memory—our shared soundscapes, if you will. In a rare occurrence for Dave, he also used actual, real-world words in a series responding to the 1965 Indo-Pak war. For example, in 'Shaheedon Ke Shabd' (gouache, watercolour and ink on paper, 1965) you can make out words like 'Goli' and 'Chetavni' in the backdrop, words of war, basically.

According to Kishore Singh, head of Exhibitions and Publications, DAG, "Shanti *bhai's* works through the '60s and the '70s were very interesting because while there was colour, the canvases tended to be monochrome. In the series that responds to the 1965 Indo-Pak war, the background textures were created with government propaganda posters and public service announcements, pamphlets, that sort of thing. I had lived through this war myself as a child and I find these series of works to be very nuanced."

In Singh's essay from the companion volume, there is a touching description of the moment Dave decided to incorporate depth and sculpture-like relief/three-dimensionality into his works. It happened when he was aboard his very first flight. "I looked at the earth below, the leaping sea, its depths and its shores, and wondered about the mysteries of the submerged world. I was spontaneously inspired to use texture and impasto in my works, hoping to fathom the unknown regions of colour and form."

In the present day, when I ask Dave about that cathartic moment, he smiles and says, "Honestly, back in the 1960s, when I was doing exhibitions in London, Frankfurt and so many other foreign places, I could barely believe my luck. I never thought I would get the chance to step aboard a plane and travel to a different country, let alone get the chance to actually show my work there." ■

*(**Shanti Dave: Neither Earth, Nor Sky** is on from July 15 to September 10 at DAG, 22A, Janpath Road, Windsor Place, New Delhi)*

Aditya Mani Jha

watercolour painting. The scroll changed hands twice before it was acquired in 2017 by Rakesh Sahni, owner of Kolkata's Rasa Art Gallery and an archivist. "It was initially either gifted or sold by Mukherjee to a friend, who then gifted it or sold it to another friend, from whom I purchased it," says Sahni.

Born in Kolkata in 1904, Mukherjee was blind in one eye and could barely see with the other. However, he was admitted to the art programme of Santiniketan, reportedly due to Rabindranath Tagore's personal intervention. Mukherjee became a pupil of the famous artist Nandalal Bose. His own students included Satyajit Ray, who also made a documentary on Mukherjee. A memorable photo taken by Nemai Ghosh shows Ray holding the camera up to the ceiling to film Mukherjee's 'ceiling mural'.

'Scenes from Santiniketan' is alternately an ink drawing and a watercolour painting

Most of Mukherjee's works are from the time when he could still see. By the time he was 53, he had lost vision in both eyes. He died in 1980.

'Scenes from Santiniketan' is like a journey that the artist undertakes on behalf of his viewers. He is the guide who gives us glimpses into the lives of the villagers. We meet farmers drawing bullock carts as they pass through paddy fields. We go to their mud huts to catch them making toddy.

In this rhythmic flow of life, the idea that time, too, is flowing never leaves us as the artist brings in subtle changes in the depiction of nature through a palette of muted colours—a tinge of olive or green gives way to brown, for instance, to indicate that the seasons are changing. The scroll, of course, is an apt medium for conveying the idea of the flow of time and the unravelling of life. ■

Dola Mitra

